▶ TAMIL NADU

STALIN GETS A SLOGAN

The census and an election: that's 2026 in Tamil Nadu. Renewed fears, as well as politics, over delimitation play well for DMK—for now

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PTI

GEARING UP FOR 2026 M.K. Stalin at a DMK meeting, Jun. 1; (right) Amit Shah in Madurai, a week later

IS IT A STATE-SPECIFIC ISSUE? A regional one concerning only the South? Or one that can tilt India's axis? From the national to the local, all lines intersected in a high-voltage visitation last week. Union home minister Amit Shah was in town, predicting saffron rule over Tamil Nadu next year. His speech in Madurai bristled with invocations of military strength, allegations of DMK corruption and calls for an Opposition resurgence. Amid the fire and brimstone, though, one silence rang out loud: no mention of delimitation.

It's no longer an abstract theme. With the census rollout set for 2026, its corollary also looms closer as a clear and present political vector. The mandated 'rebalancing' of the political weightage accorded to states threatens to curtail the South's clout: at least if it follows the logic of pegging the number of Lok Sabha seats to new population figures. Biggest among the potential aggrieved will be Tamil Nadu, where the issue is rapidly gaining traction.

For the ruling DMK, Shah's silence is tacit confirmation that the BJP intends to push ahead with delimitation ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election. For the AIADMK, which recently returned to the BJP-led NDA after attending a southern states' conclave in March that unanimously opposed population-based delimitation, it's a tightrope walk. After all, this theme could become what GST, NEET and the National Education Policy (NEP) once were: a lightning rod for Tamil politics. One that may not stop flashing with the 2026 assembly election.

SHRINKING POWER?

Tamil Nadu has 39 Lok Sabha seats—7.2 per cent of the House. On updated population data, that could drop to as few as 31. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has demanded a constitutional guarantee that Tamil Nadu's representation will not be reduced. In 1976, during the Emergency, the 42nd Amendment froze for 25 years the number of Lok Sabha seats per state based on the 1971 census—the idea was to avoid penalising states that implemented family planning. The 84th Amendment in 2002 extended the